

1. Tell me about a time you improved a complete system, not just one API.

STAR Answer

S: Our whole service was slow because of too many DB calls across modules.

T: I had to improve overall system performance.

A: I created caching for repeated data, reduced joins, added indexing, and removed unnecessary calls.

R: System response time improved by 40–50% and load on DB dropped a lot.

2. Describe a time you made an architectural decision that helped the project.

STAR Answer

S: Our old service was monolithic and changes were risky.

T: I needed to suggest a safer architecture.

A: I proposed microservices split, created clear boundaries, and designed APIs.

R: Deployment became safer, and new features were released faster.

3. Tell me about a situation where you handled production outage.

STAR Answer

S: One night, our service was down due to a queue backlog.

T: I had to restore service quickly.

A: I paused consumers, cleared dead messages, increased consumer count, and added alerts.

R: System was back in 20 minutes and issue never repeated.

4. Describe a time you coached your team during a complex feature.

STAR Answer

S: A feature involved Kafka + microservices + DB changes.

T: Team was confused about flow.

A: I explained the design, divided ownership, paired with juniors, and reviewed their code daily.

R: Feature was delivered smoothly with fewer bugs.

5. Tell me about a time you reduced deployment or release risk.

STAR Answer

S: Releases were failing because tests were outdated and manual.

T: I needed to make releases safer.

A: I created automated test suites, improved CI/CD pipeline, and added rollback steps.

R: Deployment failures dropped and releases became stable.

6. Describe a time you challenged a decision that was risky.**STAR Answer**

S: Management wanted to push an unfinished feature for a client demo.

T: It was risky and could break things.

A: I explained the risk with examples, suggested a safe mock/demo environment.

R: They agreed, and the demo went smoothly without touching production.

7. Tell me about a time you fixed a deep root cause, not just a visible bug.**STAR Answer**

S: We kept getting random null pointer issues.

T: Everyone was only fixing symptoms.

A: I traced full logs, found that a background job was sending incomplete data, and fixed that job.

R: All related errors disappeared permanently.

8. Describe a time you handled a difficult stakeholder or product manager.**STAR Answer**

S: Product manager kept changing requirements last minute.

T: It was affecting delivery.

A: I set up a simple process: freeze requirements per sprint, clarify changes through official tickets.

R: Work became predictable and PM respected the process.

9. Tell me about a situation where you optimized a batch job or heavy process.**STAR Answer**

S: Our nightly batch job ran for 4 hours and often failed.

T: Needed major improvement.

A: I analyzed queries, parallelized work, and added retries for unstable steps.

R: Job time reduced to 45 minutes and failures stopped.

10. Describe a time you identified a future problem and prevented it early.

STAR Answer

S: I noticed our API could not scale because of sync calls to external service.

T: Needed to prevent future bottleneck.

A: I redesigned the flow to async patterns, added caching, and introduced queue-based processing.

R: When traffic increased later, system handled it without issues.